

LIVING MINDFULLY 1: RADICAL SELF-HONESTY

A Somatic & Contemplative Practice Workbook

“Spiritual practice is an invitation to shift our energy away from a strictly outward analysis and move that inwards towards an internal investigation. We are here to contemplate and investigate the protective stories that obscure us from seeing the whole truth.”

Part 1: The Lens of Bias, Social 'Hats' & The Internal Committee

We do not see the world as it is, but as we are. Our perceptions are sculpted by our conditioning—our past trauma, ancestral patterns, and the rigid belief systems we carry. Under normal circumstances, we go about our day wearing different mental “**hats**.” These hats are the natural, healthy relational situations we find ourselves in—such as being a driver in a car, a shopper at the grocery store, a coworker at work, or a parent or child interacting with family. As we move through our day, our personality naturally shifts and adapts to meet the exact experience and moment we are in. There is even a default mode hat we wear when we are completely alone with our own minds. This fluid adaptation is a natural and healthy part of interacting with our world.

However, this natural flow of meeting life is easily **hijacked** by our internal experience. When intense physical discomfort, raw emotions, or rigid biases flare up, they force their way to the top of our attention and become our dominant **priority**. Once this hijacking occurs, the internal friction becomes the primary force driving us. We stop naturally responding to the relational moments (our hats) and start reacting out of resistance and survival, allowing our entire day to contract around defending ourselves from the discomfort.

The Boardroom of the Mind: The Internal Committee

Committee Member	Primary Drive / Habitual Action	My Personal Examples
The Driver of Convenience	Fabricates small stories, rationalizations, or omissions to avoid immediate friction, awkwardness, or minor accountability. Operates on the 'fudge factor'—cheating just enough to benefit while maintaining a 'good person' self-image.	
The Defender of Status	Exaggerates achievements, downplays failures, and constructs an idealized identity or protective armor. Constantly seeks to impress others, protect reputation, or win arguments.	
The Voice of Self-Judgment	Reacts with harsh self-criticism, internal shame, and the 'trance of unworthiness.' Keeps the internal dialogue active, anxious, and deeply divided.	

Reflection Prompt: Think of a recent moment where your natural personality (your hat) was hijacked by an internal emotion, bias, or physical discomfort, turning it into a driving priority. Describe the moment and which committee member took the wheel.

Part 2: Somatic Priority & The Radical Diagnostic Question

Neuroscience reveals that honesty is our brain's default baseline. Dishonesty is resource-heavy, forcing the prefrontal cortex to manage both the truth and the lie, imposing a heavy 'cognitive tax'. Repeated deceptions desensitize the amygdala (our emotional braking system), making further deceptions easier. Somatic research shows that holding an internal split—such as pretending to be okay when we are not, or letting our internal agitation hijack our relationships—manifests in the physical body as systemic fatigue, muscle tension, and restricted breathing.

The Somatic Priority

When our discomfort becomes our priority, we stop responding to what is in front of us. Our actions are no longer guided by wise choice; they are driven by the urgent, somatic need to escape the pressure. If we have head pressure (feeling like an inflated balloon) or bodily pain, that discomfort hijacks our attentional hierarchy. We shoot ourselves with a **“second arrow”** of mental resistance—spinning stories (*‘Why me?’*, ‘What if this never stops?’*) and fidgeting to escape. But physical fidgeting to escape pain is simply a mirror of mental fidgeting to run from uncomfortable emotions. By doing so, we trigger a cycle of mental resistance: *Pain × Resistance = Suffering*.

The Diagnostic Tool: Mindful Investigation

To break this somatic hijacking and return to safe, integrated alignment, we must step out of the boardroom of defensive thoughts and turn attention inward. Let your breath anchor you, look directly at the raw somatic sensation of your driving priority, and ask the sharp diagnostic question that cuts through the mental story:

“What am I unwilling to feel?”

Somatic Grounding Prompt: Bring to mind a current situation in your life where you feel divided, anxious, or defensive. Gently sweep your awareness through your physical body. Locate where the tension is hiding (e.g., tight chest, clenched jaw, shallow breath).

Now, breathe directly into that physical sensation, drop the stories, and ask: ‘What am I unwilling to feel?’ (e.g., fear of vulnerability, shame, anger, grief). Write down the raw, direct feeling without any narrative filters:

What is a concrete way you can practice ‘sitting on the box’ with this direct physical sensation or emotion this week, rather than fidgeting or spinning stories to escape it?

Part 3: Training the Observer & The Power of Uncertainty

Mindfulness is not a passive escape; it is an active, experiential investigation—a practice known in the Buddhist scriptures as **Ehipassiko** (“come and see for yourself”). We are invited to transition from the passive, automatic chatter of our internal committee to active, wise investigation. We build a robust inner gatekeeper—**The Observer (The Watcher)**—by deploying three forms of fabrication (*sankhara*) to retrain the mind's habitual conditioning:

Type of Fabrication	How We Use It to Retrain the Mind	My Practical Commitment
Bodily Fabrication	Using the breath (e.g., the physiological sigh, breathing into the tension) to calm and steady the nervous system, signaling somatic safety.	
Verbal Fabrication	Using directed thought and evaluation to talk to ourselves in a more skillful way (e.g., replacing harsh self-judgment with the kind voice of self-mothering).	
Mental Fabrication	Consciously adjusting our perceptions and labels (e.g., viewing head pressure not as an attack, but as a fluid 'balloon of sensation' or 'cloud of emptiness').	

The Honesty of Uncertainty: The Spacious 'Not Sure'

The ultimate expression of internal honesty is our willingness to be uncertain. We often feel an intense, urgent pressure to know exactly why things are happening, who is to blame, or how to fix it. We spin endless verbal explanations (*papañca*) that only stir things up and multiply our suffering. When we let go of our need to be the absolute authority on our lives, we drop the struggle. We step into the present open-handed, resting in the quiet, radically honest wisdom of “**not sure.**”

The 'Not Sure' Commitment: Write down one area of your life (a relationship, a health struggle, or a future worry) where you can commit to laying down your exhausting mental blueprints, replacing them with a spacious, honest 'not sure'. How does that shift feel in your physical body?

What is your commitment to connecting with the silent, spacious Knower (the Observer) this week when your mind begins to drift or react?

“By seeing the truth of your own mind, you open the portal to a freedom that no condition can take away.”